

Tasin Academy

Opposite to Alekanda Govt College, Barishal

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In 1921, **Leela Nag** (also known as Leela Roy for her marriage with Anil Chandra Roy, an Indian National Congress leader) was the first woman to be admitted to the MA in English at the University of Dhaka. Breaking patriarchal barriers, Leela Nag established the identity of the Department of English from the very beginning as a platform for progressive and liberal ideas. Although her decision to join the Department of English was initially met with resistance, she achieved her goal with a special permission from the then Vice Chancellor Philip Hartog and fulfilled her dream of graduating from the University of Dhaka. In 1923, she was the first woman to receive an M.A. from the Department of English.

But Leela Nag's legacy goes beyond the confines of classrooms. While she was a student, she formed the Dhaka Women's Committee and raised funds for the 1921 Bengal flood victims. She was actively involved in the empowerment of women in society. In 1923, she founded Deepali Sangha, which served as a training institute for anti-colonial activists. Between 1927 and 1928, she established the first self-defense institute for girls in Bengal. Then, at the 1928 Calcutta Congress Session, she presented a paper on the history of women's movement in Bengal as a delegate, and by 1929, Leela Nag had successfully founded 12 free primary schools for girls. Apart from her contribution to women's emancipation, Leela consistently voiced her opinions in politics as well. She had been imprisoned on several occasions.

When the Subcontinent was embroiled in turmoil during the Partition, Leela Nag set up camps for victims of Noakhali riots and refugees from East Bengal in 1946. She was the only Bengali woman elected to the Constituent Assembly of Bengal. Looking at the other women who studied in the Department of English, Leela Nag broke the glass ceiling on so many levels and fulfilled all the criteria of a citizen, reformer, feminist, and social activist. She is considered a rebel, reformer, social activist, and change agent, whose legacy remains in East Bengal. In 1947, she set up camps for the victims of Partition.

1.A. Choose the correct answer from the alternatives:

(1x5=5)

(a) What does the term *patriarchal* refer to in the context of the passage?

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|-----------------------------------|------------------------------|
| (i) A system where men hold power | (ii) A capitalist society |
| (iii) A temporary achievement | (iv) A financial inheritance |

(b) The word *legacy* in the passage stands for:

- | | |
|-------------------------------|--------------------------|
| (i) A lasting influence | (ii) A personal conflict |
| (iii) A financial inheritance | (iv) Elite group |

(c) Who was the first woman to be admitted to the MA in English at the University of Dhaka?

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|--------------------|----------------|------------------|----------------------|
| (i) Sarojini Naidu | (ii) Leela Nag | (iii) Kamala Das | (iv) Rani Lakshmibai |
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(d) What committee did Leela Nag form while still a student?

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|--------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| (i) Dhaka Women's Committee | (ii) Kolkata Women's Committee |
| (iii) Bengal Women's Committee | (iv) All India Women's Committee |

(e) What does the phrase *breaking patriarchal barriers* imply in the passage?

- (i) Creating new societal norms (ii) Building schools for girls
(iii) Fighting against male-dominated systems (iv) Disobeying academic rules

1.B. Answer the following questions:

(5x2=10)

- (a) What was the significance of Leela Nag's admission to the University of Dhaka?
(b) How did Leela Nag's specific efforts in the Bengal floods reflect her commitment to social activism?
(c) What role did the Deepali Sangha play in the anti-colonial struggle?
(d) Why was the first self-defense institute for girls in Bengal important?

2. Read the passage and complete the table below with the given information. 1x10=10

Who/What	Event/Activity	Where/Place/Whom	When/How/Why
Leela Nag	married	(i).....	
She	Was the first woman MA Student	(ii).....	(iii).....
(iv).....	Gave special permission to Leela Nag	(v).....	To join the Department of English
(vi).....	To join the Department of English	Dhaka University	(vii).....
Leela Nag	(viii).....		With special permission from the authority
Her Legacy	goes	(ix).....	
She	Was involved in the empowerment of women	(x).....	Throughout her life

Or,

Read the above passage and make a flowchart showing the Leela Nag's struggling life.

(One is done for you.)

2x5=10

1. Admitted to MA in Dhaka University	→	2	→	3	→	4	→	5	→	6
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3. Summary Writing

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Write a summary of the passage in your own words.